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Dalit Rights

When in 1956 Dr Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar and lakhs of his Dalit followers repudiated the inferior status imposed on them for centuries and became Buddhists, indirectly affirming nonviolence, they performed a feat of noble defiance. It caused some to feel that the liberty, equality and fraternity enjoined in our Constitution might become the actual goals of Indian society. Picking up the social justice baton in the 1980s, Kanshi Ram attempted to create an 'invincible' alliance of Dalits, deprived non-Dalits and Muslims for ending social and economic oppression. The imagined alliance proved elusive, yet the social justice call personified by Dr Ambedkar, and pursued by Kanshi Ram and others, remains a powerful vision.



GETTY IMAGES

Bhoodan Movement

Begun in April 1951 in response to the needs of landless Dalits in a village in Nalgonda district in today's Telangana state, **Vinoba Bhave**'s Bhoodan or land-gift drive is thought to have resulted in donations by 1957 of around 4.5 million acres of land, a large proportion in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. Although a few gifts were bogus, and some recipients faced difficulty registering donated land, the remarkable Bhoodan movement had social, economic, political and psychological ramifications. A belief entered minds that India's lands were meant for the needs of everyone.

Liberalisation

Launched in 1959 by Chennai's C. Rajagopalachari, Mumbai's Minoo Masani, Andhra's N.G. Ranga and associates, the Swatantra Party raised a much-needed voice against 'the licence-permit raj', an unintended byproduct of independent India's anti-poverty and egalitarian policies. Over three decades later, in 1991, finance minister **Manmohan Singh**, backed by prime minister Narasimha Rao, began removing obstacles to enterprise placed by the State, and the Indian economy took off. The runway for that take-off was painstakingly laid by the earlier critics of the licence-permit raj.



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